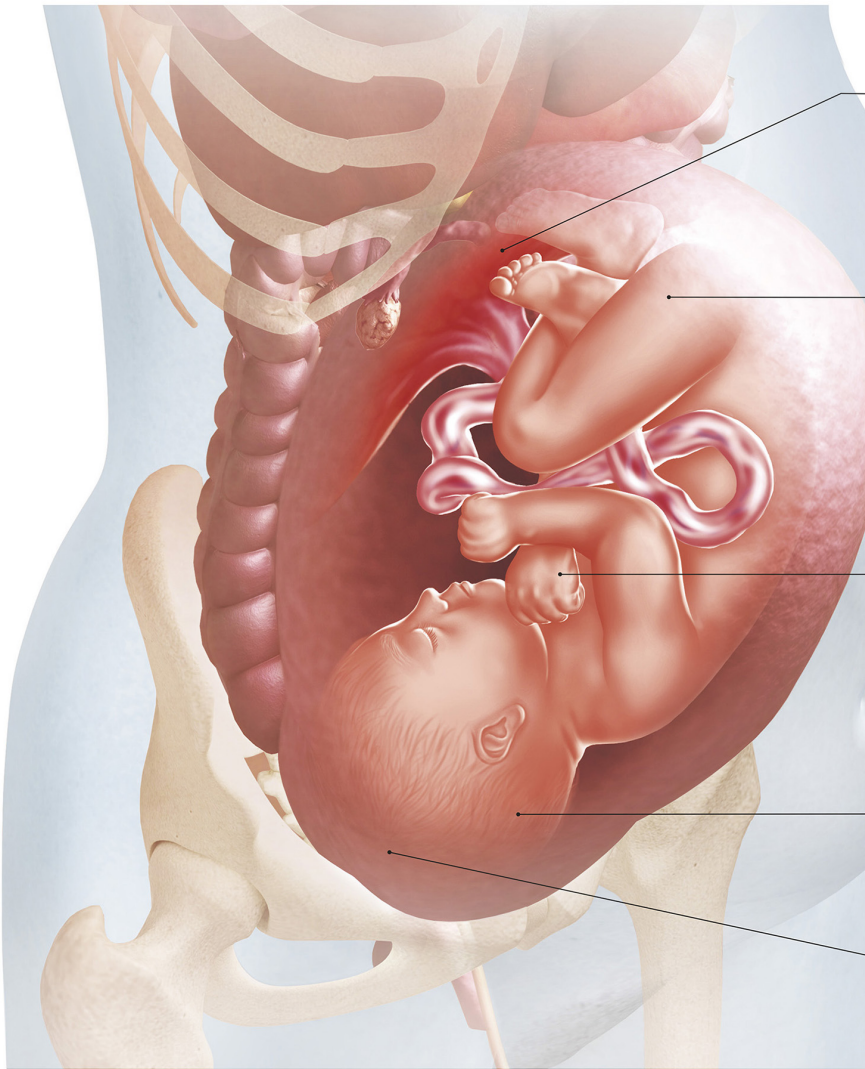




The placenta has reached its full size and is spread out like a plate. It will continue to function for the full duration of the pregnancy.

Parts of the skeleton, particularly the long bones of the arms and legs, have hardened, in a process known as ossification.

The hands may be curled into fists, grasping the umbilical cord, or free-floating with fingers outstretched. The grasp reflex is very strong.

The head may now be fully engaged. There are several normal variations in position and the direction in which the baby is facing.

At 38 weeks the average crown to heel length is 19.6 in (49.8 cm) and the average weight is 6.8 lb (3.1 kg).